

CHAPTER SIX: SYSTEMS AND DRAMA

"Just fear me, love me, do as I say, and I will be your slave."

— Jareth, The Goblin King, *Labyrinth*

We all play games of pretend, with ourselves or with others. The former has the advantage of being of unified purpose and creative direction. When friends are included though, ah, what a game! Still, when many minds and hearts tell the same tale, differing opinions and ideas are bound to arise, and that can leave the outcome uncertain. This is where rules come in — with a system for resolving these questions, play proceeds smoothly, and one narrative emerges from many perspectives.

We offer the following as a collection of systems for deciding and tracking a variety of actions, needs, and dangers. In this chapter we provide a deeper understanding of the changeling heart (including both Glamour and Banality), and the twin-but-opposing threats of Bedlam and being Undone. We also discuss combat, be it a glorious chimerical battle with pennants fluttering in the wind or a deadly serious knife-fight in a back alley, along with ways to hurt and to heal, and a myriad of other situations your characters might find themselves in. We cap it off with an example of play to show how all these systems work together.

Dramatic Systems

The only thing limiting your actions during a game are your imagination and your character's ability. Characters — both player and Storyteller personalities — may attempt numerous diverse and complicated activities. The Storyteller is responsible for keeping all of this action organized while determining success or failure for all characters.

Dramatic systems simplify the Storyteller's job by supplying rules for a number of common activities. Storytellers should, and will undoubtedly have to, invent their own dramatic systems for new situations. The list of systems below is in no way exhaustive, but provides a solid foundation on which to base events.

Automatic Feats

Many actions the characters take during the game are automatic because they are so basic they need no rolls. Walking, jogging, or running always succeed — unless extenuating circumstances arise. These might be when pursuing or being pursued,